Clear the Mac

Free up a full computer with Claude, without losing a single file

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What happened

A founder's MacBook Pro had a 500 GB disk with **11 GB free**. It kept warning about low memory. The real cause was the disk: macOS uses free disk space as overflow when memory fills up, and there wasn't any left.

The files stayed on the laptop for a reason most people will recognize. Once something moves to an external drive, it might as well be gone, because there's no way to know what went where or whether the copy is any good.

Over one afternoon and one overnight copy, working with Claude Code:

	Before	After
Free space	11 GB	**71 GB**
Moved off	—	24 folders, 20,434 files, 64 GB
Copies of each moved file	1	**2**, on two separate drives, every file fingerprint-checked
How to find something	memory	a tick-off register + a READ-ME left in every emptied folder

Nothing was lost. Before deleting, every file was checked again. Two folders were held back for a closer look, and both turned out to be safe.

How it works

1. **Measure.** Claude shows you free space, memory pressure, and your biggest folders.
2. **List.** Every big folder goes into a register (a spreadsheet, or Notion, Google Sheets or Airtable) with its size, how much of it is photos and video, and when it was last touched. Claude suggests what to move: untouched for a year = archive, 3–12 months = pull back later, recent = keep.
3. **You decide.** You mark each row *keep*, *archive* or *pull back*. Nothing marked keep is ever touched.

4. **Two copies, verified.** Each approved folder is copied to **two** external drives, and every file's fingerprint (md5) is checked on both.
5. **You say the word.** Nothing is deleted until you tell Claude to clear it. Right before deleting, every file is checked again, and any folder that changed is held back.
6. **A trail stays behind.** Each emptied folder keeps its place and holds a READ-ME saying which drives it's on. A manifest lists every file and both locations.
7. **Pull back any time.** "Pull back *folder*" restores it from either drive and checks every file.

What it's worth

Run `scripts/savings.py` with your own numbers. Every price is an input, so check current prices before you quote one.

Example (64 GB freed, drives already owned):

What it replaces	Value
Buying the next computer one storage tier smaller (e.g. 1 TB instead of 2 TB)	~$400
A 2 TB cloud plan for the same files, 3 years	~$360
The same space as built-in storage	~$26
Cost of two drive copies	$0 (owned) / ~$4 (new drives, at about $0.06/GB)

The insight: gigabytes on an external drive are cheap, about 7× cheaper than built-in storage even with two copies. The real saving is buying your next computer with the storage you actually need and putting the money into memory instead. This system is what makes the smaller tier safe.

What you need

- A Mac (or any computer with Python 3.8+), and Claude Code
- Two external drives with room to spare, formatted so your computer can write to them. On a Mac, an NTFS drive is read-only.
- About 15 minutes of decisions. The copying runs on its own.

Install

Copy the `clear-the-mac` folder into `~/.claude/skills/`, then in Claude Code type:

```
/clear-the-mac
```

Claude asks three questions (which drives, where you want the list, anything off-limits) and walks you through the rest.

Make it a habit

- **Use a trigger, not a calendar.** When free space drops below a line you pick, run it again. It only lists new folders.
- **Keep one drive somewhere else.** Two copies in the same room are one fire away from zero copies.
- **Do it by hand a few times before automating it.**